

# 168 Luke

*"The beloved physician," Paul's loyal companion, and by early tradition the writer of Luke and Acts.*

Luke is named only three times in the New Testament, all in Paul's letters. Paul calls him "the beloved physician" and a fellow worker, and in Paul's last imprisonment Luke is the one friend still with him. The early church also named Luke as the author of the Gospel of Luke and the Acts of the Apostles, which together make up about a quarter of the New Testament. Neither book names its writer, but in parts of Acts the narrator says "we," as if he traveled with Paul. If Luke is that writer, he crossed into Europe with Paul, went with him to Jerusalem, and survived a shipwreck on the way to Rome. His life shows careful work and faithful friendship.

## At a glance

|                     |                                                                                                |
|---------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Name                | Greek <i>Loukas</i> ; "Lucas" in Philemon 24 (KJV)                                             |
| Work                | "The beloved physician" (Colossians 4:14)                                                      |
| Background          | Probably a Gentile, since Paul lists him apart from his Jewish co-workers (Colossians 4:10–14) |
| When                | With Paul at times from c. AD 49–50 into the AD 60s                                            |
| Key places          | Troas, Philippi, Jerusalem, Caesarea, Malta, Rome                                              |
| Key people          | Paul, Theophilus, John Mark, Demas, Timothy                                                    |
| Traditionally wrote | The Gospel of Luke and the Acts of the Apostles                                                |
| Named in            | Colossians 4:14; Philemon 24; 2 Timothy 4:11                                                   |

*"Luke, the beloved physician, and Demas, greet you."*

Colossians 4:14, KJV

# The life of Luke

Dates are approximate (AD). If Luke wrote Acts, the "we" passages (Acts 16:10–17; 20:5–21:18; 27:1–28:16) show when he was with Paul. That link is the traditional view, not a statement of the text.

|                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>c. AD 49–50</b><br><i>Troas</i>              | ● <b>"We" join Paul</b><br>After Paul's vision of the man of Macedonia, the narrator writes, "immediately we endeavoured to go into Macedonia." The first "we" passage runs through the founding of the church at Philippi. <i>Acts 16:10–17</i> |
| <b>c. AD 57</b><br><i>Philippi to Jerusalem</i> | ● <b>The collection journey</b><br>The "we" resumes as Paul sails from Philippi after the days of unleavened bread, through Troas and Miletus, then on to Tyre, Caesarea and Jerusalem. <i>Acts 20:5–21:18</i>                                   |
| <b>c. AD 57–59</b><br><i>Caesarea</i>           | ● <b>Two years of waiting</b><br>Paul is held in Caesarea under Felix and then Festus. The "we" returns when the voyage begins there, so many think Luke stayed nearby, perhaps gathering eyewitness accounts. <i>Acts 24:27; 27:1</i>           |
| <b>c. AD 59–60</b><br><i>At sea</i>             | ● <b>Storm and shipwreck</b><br>The detailed account of the voyage, the long storm and the wreck on Malta reads like an eyewitness report. On the island Paul heals many of the sick. <i>Acts 27:1–28:10</i>                                     |
| <b>c. AD 60–62</b><br><i>Rome</i>               | ● <b>With Paul in prison</b><br>Paul sends greetings from "Luke, the beloved physician" and names "Lucas" among his fellow workers. <i>Acts 28:16; Colossians 4:14; Philemon 24</i>                                                              |
| <b>c. AD 64–67</b><br><i>Rome</i>               | ● <b>The last friend</b><br>In Paul's final letter, others have gone away. "Only Luke is with me." <i>2 Timothy 4:10–11</i>                                                                                                                      |

# Key activities

Neither the Gospel of Luke nor Acts names its author. From the late second century, writers such as Irenaeus name Luke, and many scholars accept this. Others think the author was a later Christian who used a travel source for the "we" passages.

- 
- 1 Investigated carefully. The writer drew on eyewitnesses and set out to write "in order." *Luke 1:1-3*
  - 2 Wrote so others could be sure. He addressed his work to Theophilus, "that thou mightest know the certainty" of what he had been taught. *Luke 1:3-4; Acts 1:1*
  - 3 Crossed into Europe with Paul. He joined the mission from Troas to Philippi. *Acts 16:10-12*
  - 4 Traveled to Jerusalem with Paul. He was part of the group that went up with Paul and the collection. *Acts 20:5-6; 21:15-18*
  - 5 Survived a shipwreck. He sailed with Paul the prisoner and was wrecked on Malta. *Acts 27:1, 41-44; 28:1*
  - 6 Served as a physician. Paul calls him "the beloved physician." *Colossians 4:14*
  - 7 Labored alongside Paul. Paul lists him among his "fellowlabourers." *Philemon 24*
  - 8 Stayed when others left. In Paul's last imprisonment Luke alone remained with him. *2 Timothy 4:10-11*
- 

## Group notes

---

---

---

---

---

---

# Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links. Luke's Antioch origin and later life are tradition only.

## Old Testament

|                      |                                                     |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| Echo: 1 Kings 11:41  | Kings, like Luke, points to earlier written records |
| Echo: Proverbs 17:17 | "A friend loveth at all times"                      |

## New Testament

|                                       |                                                                  |
|---------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Colossians 4:14                       | "Luke, the beloved physician"                                    |
| Philemon 24                           | "Lucas" among Paul's fellowlabourers                             |
| 2 Timothy 4:11                        | "Only Luke is with me"; Paul's authorship debated                |
| Luke 1:1–4; Acts 1:1–2                | Both addressed to Theophilus: one work in two parts              |
| Acts 16:10–17; 20:5–21:18; 27:1–28:16 | The "we" passages                                                |
| Tradition                             | Some identify him with the unnamed brother of 2 Corinthians 8:18 |

### For discussion

1. *Observe:* What does Luke say about his method in Luke 1:1–4?
2. *Understand:* Why might it matter that the Gospel's writer had "perfect understanding of all things from the very first" (Luke 1:3)?
3. *Apply:* Luke stayed with Paul when others left. Who needs a friend who stays?
4. *Apply:* What skill of yours could you offer to your church or community?